Walking with RJ

By Stephanie Peirolo

STEPHANIE: **(Pgs 82-88)** I was 23 years old when I had my first child. I was in labor for three days before my son, RJ, was born. So when I first laid eyes on him, I felt nothing but exhaustion. I said, *"This is it?"* It wasn't until about an hour later, when I woke up and he was in my arms, wrapped up, that I felt it -- that rush of maternal love, that primal adoration. And I thought, *This **is** it. This is how the species survives.*

I had another child, a daughter, Emma. And soon after Emma was born, their father and I divorced. He moved to Europe, and I raised the kids by myself.

Fast-forward. We're living in Seattle. The kids are in high school and doing great. They get straight A's. The only thing RJ gets in trouble for is wearing his hair long. He goes to Catholic school and you're supposed to have your hair above your collar. But RJ plays the drums, he's in theater, so he wears his hair long.

In the fall of his junior year, he's cast as the lead in the school play. He's going to be Atticus Finch in *To Kill a Mockingbird*, so he has to get his hair cut. And I remember him walking out of the barbershop. He had a crew cut, and he was six feet tall and impossibly handsome. He had this kind of shy smile, and I thought, *This is the man he is becoming.*

INTRODUCTION

No mother should have to choose between saving her child's life and navigating the maze of health insurance coverage. But that's exactly what Stephanie Peirolo faced when her son RJ suffered a traumatic brain injury. She thought the hardest part would be watching RJ fight for his life not fighting a system that puts profits before people.

Health insurance "coverage" quickly vanished behind automated phone lines and unreadable policies. And when Stephanie is fired from her job for taking too much time off, what little insurance safety net was in place disappeared too. While her son struggled to hold up his head, and relearn basic things like swallowing and speaking, Stephanie Peirolo discovered that our healthcare system doesn't break only the sick. It breaks the families who love them, too.

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STEPHANIE: In January of his junior year, a cop showed up at our door, and he said, "Are you RJ's mom?" I said yes. He said, "There's been an accident." I said, "Is he dead?" And he said, "Not yet, but we have to get to the hospital right away." So the cop drove me to Harborview, which is not the closest hospital to our house, but it is the one with a trauma center. We went in the back way, where the ambulance bays are. Someone was hosing blood out of the back of an ambulance, all of this blood, and I remember thinking, *That's my son's.*

It took a couple of hours for me to find out what had happened. RJ had been driving to his best friend's. He had his seat belt on. He didn't have drugs or alcohol in his system, and he was hit from the side in a blind intersection. He sustained a traumatic brain injury (or TBI), and he had broken his pelvis. At the time I didn't understand the gravity of a TBI.

I was the vice president of an advertising agency. They had just changed their insurance plan. Keep in mind, it's the first week of January. So I didn't have a list of my benefits. What I have is an insurance card with a phone number on the back. So while RJ's in the ICU, I call the phone number, and the voice on the other end of the phone told me, "ICU is covered, intensive brain-injury rehab is covered, skilled nursing facility . . ." And they list off all these great benefits. And I remember thinking, *Thank God I don't have to worry about insurance.*

When RJ was discharged from the ICU, he was transferred to the rehab facility, and shortly after, they called me and said, "Your insurance company called and said RJ's benefits are up on Friday." I said, "No, no, no, no, he's got many more benefits," but of course I just had a voice on the other end of the phone.

So I went over there, and said, "Where am I supposed to take him? He's in a coma." They said, "Well, there's always foster care." *(shocked pause)* So Emma and I took RJ home. We made a hospital room in his bedroom. He had PEG tube in his stomach, and that's how we pumped in nutrition. They taught us how to do physical therapy. Emma was 15, and she said, "Mom, I will help you take care of RJ in any way I can, as long as it doesn't involve the

Speedo zone." So when he needed to be changed, because of course he was in diapers, she would bring me a bucket of warm water and washcloths and I would clean him up.

Coming out of a coma is nothing like what you see in the movies. It's a long, slow, painstaking process. It took RJ months to learn how to hold up his head. We put him in his wheelchair, and his friends would come by every day after school.

Months had passed, and I still couldn't get the Summary Plan Description. I kept calling [the insurance company]. But I realized this not a bureaucratic mix-up, this is intentional and this is illegal. This is a violation of a law called ERISA - the Employee Retirement Income Security Act of 1974. So I called an ERISA lawyer and told him the situation, and he said, "I can help you, but you're going to have to give me a retainer of $30,000." I said, "Let me be clear. I'm a single parent. I have paid to set up a hospital room in my house. I pay a nurse to sit with my son, so that I stay employed so I can keep this insurance. I don't have $30,000." And he said, "I'm sorry; I can't help you."

At this point, I was completely exhausted and I was very concerned about getting fired because I'd taken so much time off. So, I applied for and was granted FMLA leave. The Family Medical Leave Act says you can take 12 weeks of unpaid leave to care for a sick family member and they have to keep your job for you. Shortly into my FMLA leave, I was fired. These things are illegal, but you can't call the police on a corporation. And I couldn't afford an attorney.

When RJ turned 18, he was able to go on Medicaid, and I made the decision to put him in a nursing home. I found a facility that specialized in patients with TBIs. All their patients were on Medicaid, so they didn't have much money. But they took really good care of RJ, and he continued to make slow progress. He could do thumbs-up for yes, thumbs-down for no. We were visiting him, and Emma was teasing him, and he flipped her off. I got really excited 'cause that's like some manual dexterity happening there, right? And then he turned to me and he put his hand down because, brain injury notwithstanding, he was not about to flip off his mother.

Before RJ's accident, I had to drag him to Mass on Sundays, but after the accident, he loved to go to church.I'd say, "Do you want to go to Mass today?" He'd put his thumbs up. He learned how to put money in the collection plate again. And when he learned how to swallow – because apparently swallowing is incredibly complex; that took like a year to come back -- he could take Communion, and you could see it provided him so much solace.

In August of 2005, RJ got very sick, and we thought it was the flu. He still had his PEG tube in his stomach, and it had fallen out. That happens, and when it falls out, you put it back in. You're supposed to X-ray to make sure you have it in the right place. Well, this facility couldn't afford an X-ray machine, so they guessed and they guessed wrong.

His food had been going into his abdominal cavity and he had sepsis. At the hospital, the surgeon took me aside and said, "I can operate on RJ, and I might save his life, but he's going to go back into a deep coma, and he will never come out. Or you can let him go. You have to decide."

So I went down the hall and called his father, who was still in Europe, and I said, "What should I do?" He said, "You're caring for him; it's your choice."

So I went into RJ's room. [He] was completely aware of what was happening, and he was afraid. His eyes were open really wide. And I said, "Honey, you're very sick, and they can't fix you. So you're gonna go to God -- you're gonna go to God, but my dad is there, and he's gonna come and find you, and I will be there soon." *(long beat as she struggles to compose herself)*

It took RJ three days to die. *(another long silence)*

[Today], RJ would be 27 years old. *Why didn't you keep him at home? If you had made more money, you could've put him in a private nursing home, then he never would've died.*

The world is so diminished without him, like there's been a total eclipse of the sun. Only I'm the only one who can see it. *(beat)* I wonder if RJ's existence is part of a larger narrative arc. If maybe this slice in time was how RJ had to work out his destiny, and maybe my job was to

walk with him. *(beat)* Between RJ's accident and his death, he was only able to say a handful of words. And the word he said most was "Mom." And there are times now where I feel RJ. I feel that he ***is***. And in those moments, I know it's his turn . . . for his love to carry me.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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